additional room for maneuver. He was still committed to the idea of trading the missiles for concessions from the United States. To get those concessions, he was prepared to go further than he had done the previous day in his letter to Kennedy; in particular, to admit openly what he had only implied up to that point—the deployment of ballistic missiles in Cuba. “We will not eliminate the conflict if we do not give satisfaction to the Americans and do not tell them that our R-12 missiles are there,” he told his colleagues. “I think that we should not be obstinate.”[15]

But Khrushchev was prepared to make such an admission only for a price. He considered the fact that Kennedy had not so far attacked Cuba a sign of weakness to be exploited. “Did we commit a mistake or not?” he asked the members of the Presidium. “This can be assessed later on,” continued Khrushchev before making his brazen new proposal: “And if we receive in return the elimination of the [US] bases in Turkey and Pakistan, then we will end up victorious.” For Khrushchev’s colleagues, his idea of throwing the missiles in Turkey into the equation came as a surprise. “Speaking frankly, we were not thinking about bases in Turkey at all,” Khrushchev’s well-informed ally Anastas Mikoyan would tell the Cuban leaders in early November 1962.[16]

The American missiles in Turkey had been very much on Khrushchev’s mind since the inception of the Cuban affair. It was no accident that the idea of dispatching nuclear weapons to Cuba had come to him in May 1962 in the Black Sea port of Varna as he publicly denounced the Americans for turning the Turkish coast into a military base. But this was Khrushchev’s first mention of Turkey not in order to argue that the Soviets had the right to place their missiles in Cuba but to suggest a potential bargain. He threw in Pakistan as well, which indicated that the idea was not yet fully formed in his mind. Since Pakistan had no nuclear weapons but served as a base for U-2 overflights of the USSR, Khrushchev was simply looking to increase the number of American strategic assets to which he could object. But as he and his aides began to work on the letter to Kennedy proposing the new deal, Turkey not only took priority over Pakistan but completely replaced it.

If one trusts Mikoyan, the idea of using the American missiles in Turkey as a bargaining chip came to Khrushchev from the US media. “During discussion of the dangerous situation we received information from